

The Effect of Boarding Strategies on Aircraft Boarding Efficiency

A Simulation-Based Study with an Exact Longest-Path (Max-Plus) Theory | Author: Zihao Huang | October 2026

Abstract

This study compares three aircraft boarding strategies — *random*, *back-to-front*, and *zoning* (5 zones) — using a single-aisle simulation. Contrary to intuition, **random boarding is the fastest and back-to-front is the slowest**, and the gap widens with stow time and cabin size. We derive an **exact theoretical model** that computes the boarding time directly (without tick-by-tick simulation) as the length of a **longest path** in a max-plus recurrence; it reproduces the simulation **bit-for-bit** (verified over >25,000 cases), and yields provable lower bounds. The theory — corroborated by measured mechanism metrics (parallelism and blocking) — explains *why* clustered boarding is slow: consecutive same-row passengers stack stowing weights on a single aisle cell and lengthen the critical path.

1. Background and Research Question

Boarding time affects on-time performance and operating cost. Airlines often use "zone boarding" or "back-to-front boarding", but whether these beat random boarding is debated. We test:

Hypothesis H: Organized strategies (back-to-front / zoning) board faster than random boarding.

2. Methods

2.1 Simulation model

- Single-aisle cabin; passengers enter from the front and walk to their row.
- On reaching the row, a passenger stows luggage, occupying the aisle for **S** ticks; followers cannot pass.
- One cell of forward motion per tick; no overtaking; one passenger enters per tick.
- Total ticks until all are seated = boarding time (smaller = faster).

2.2 Variables

Type	Variable
Independent	Boarding strategy (Random / Back-to-front / Zones-5)
Dependent	Total boarding time T (ticks)
Control (baseline)	Random boarding (normalized to 1.00)
Controlled	Rows R ; seats per row (6); entry rate (1/tick); repeats (20)

2.3 Mechanism metrics

The simulator records, each tick, the number of passengers **stowing simultaneously** (parallelism) and the number of **blocking events** (walkers stuck behind a stower).

2.4 Theoretical model: an exact longest-path (max-plus) formulation

We model boarding as a **discrete-time single-lane exclusion process** and derive an **exact recurrence** for T . Let

- cells be $1..R$; passenger i ($i = 1..N$) enters in order; r_i = target row; S = stow time;
- P_i^c = the tick at which passenger i reaches cell c ;
- $j = j_i(c)$ = the last passenger before i that reaches cell c .

Passenger i reaches cell c at the **later** of two times: its own pace, and the moment cell c becomes free:

$$P_i^c = \max(P_i^{c-1} + 1, B_i^c), \text{ where } B_i^c = \{ P_j^c + 1 + S \text{ if } r_j = c \text{ (j stows at row } c); P_j^{c+1} \text{ if } r_j > c \text{ (j passes through)} \}$$

with the exact entrance conventions (entering is its own tick; right after entering one may move an extra cell):

$$P_i^1 = \max(i, B_i^1), \quad P_i^2 = \max(P_i^1, B_i^2), \quad P_i^c = \max(P_i^{c-1} + 1, B_i^c) \text{ for } c \geq 3.$$

At the entrance cell, when the passenger ahead only passes through ($r_j > 1$), entering is its own step, so $B_i^1 = P_j^2 + 1$.

The finish time of passenger i and the total time are

$$F_i = P_i^{r_i} + [r_i \geq 2] + S - 1, \quad T = \max_i F_i.$$

Interpretation. Every P_i^c is a *max of two terms* ("my own pace" vs "waiting for the person ahead"), so T is the length of the **longest chain of waits** — a **longest path** (last-passage percolation) value on the space–time lattice.

2.4.1 Worked example

Take $R = 3$ rows, one seat per row, $S = 1$, and boarding order $r = [3, 1, 2]$ (passenger 1 goes to row 3, passenger 2 to row 1, passenger 3 to row 2). Applying the recurrence cell by cell:

Passenger i	r_i	Cell-by-cell computation	Finish F_i
1	3	$P_1 = \max(1, 0) = 1; P_2 = \max(1, 0) = 1; P_3 = \max(1+1, 0) = 2$	$2 + 1 + 1 - 1 = 3$
2	1	$B_1 = P_1^2 + 1 = 2; P_1 = \max(2, 2) = 2$	$2 + 0 + 1 - 1 = 2$
3	2	$B_1 = P_2^1 + S = 3 \rightarrow P_1 = \max(3, 3) = 3; B_2 = P_1^3 = 2 \rightarrow P_2 = \max(3, 2) = 3$	$3 + 1 + 1 - 1 = 4$

Thus $T = \max(3, 2, 4) = 4$, which matches the simulation exactly.

2.5 Lower bounds

Proposition 1 (entrance bound). $T \geq N$. Proof: at most one passenger enters per tick, and all N must have entered.

Proposition 2 (occupancy bound). $T \geq (\sum_i r_i + N \cdot S) / R$. Proof: passenger i occupies r_i cell-ticks while walking and S while stowing, so total occupancy is $\sum_i r_i + N \cdot S$; at most R cells can be occupied in any tick. For 6 seats per row ($\sum_i r_i = 3R(R+1)$): $T \geq 3(R+1) + 6S$.

2.6 Data collection

Strategies with randomness (Random, Zones) are run **20 times and averaged**; Back-to-front is deterministic. Results are reported relative to random (baseline = 1.00).

3. Results

3.1 Main result (R = 30 rows, S = 3)

Strategy	Average boarding time (ticks)	Relative to random
Random	331.1	1.00 (baseline)
Zones (5)	400.8	1.21
Back-to-front	627.0	1.89

Values are averages over 100 runs (random, zoning); back-to-front and strided descending are deterministic (single run).

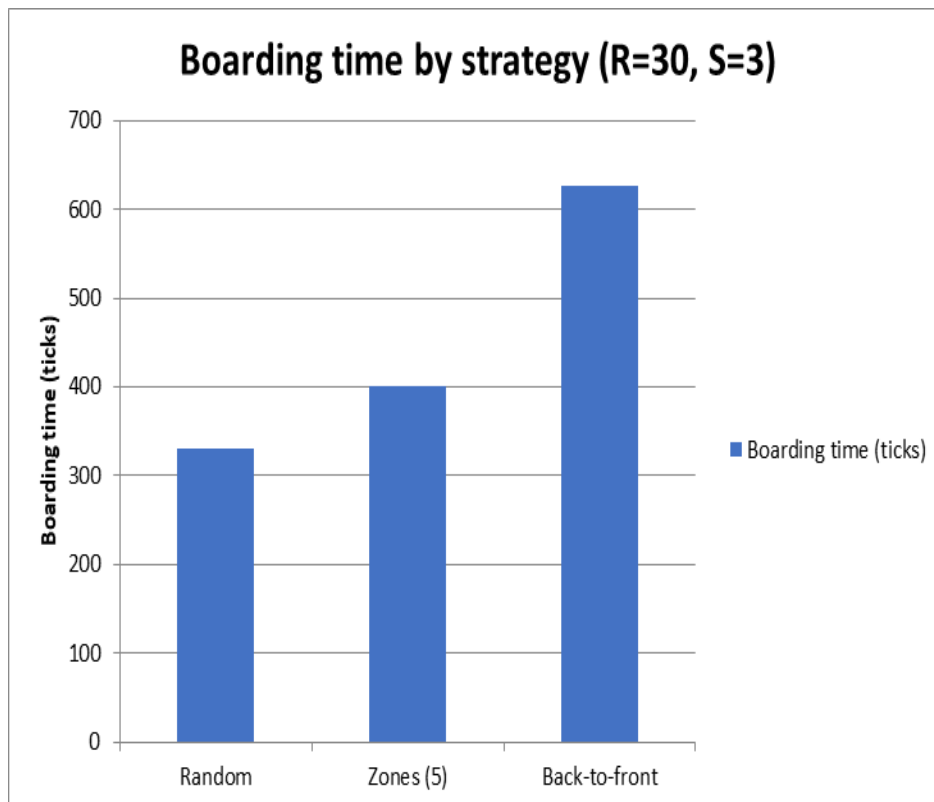


Figure 1. Boarding time by strategy (R=30, S=3): random fastest, back-to-front slowest.

3.2 Sensitivity analysis

(a) Stow time (fixed R = 30).

S	Random	Back-to-front	Zones (5)	Rel. random (back)	Rel. random (zones)
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1	239.1	325	250.0	1.36	1.05
3	331.1	627	400.8	1.89	1.21
6	472.2	1080	628.7	2.29	1.33

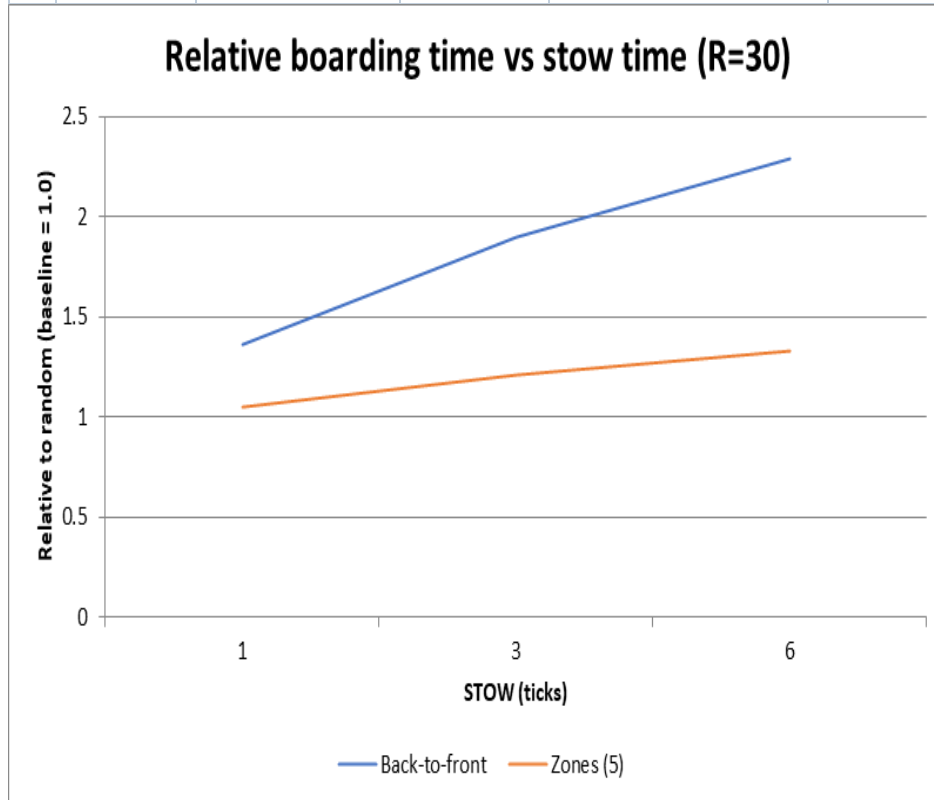


Figure 2. Relative boarding time vs stow time (R=30).

(b) Number of rows (fixed S = 3).

Rows R	Random	Back-to-front	Zones (5)	Rel. random (back)	Rel. random (zones)
20	237.2	417	290.8	1.76	1.23
30	331.1	627	400.8	1.89	1.21
40	422.7	837	503.2	1.98	1.19

3.3 Why: the empirical mechanism and its exact theory

Empirical mechanism. The measured mechanism agrees with the theory: the fastest strategy is also the most parallel. The average number of passengers stowing at the same moment is **1.09** for random versus **0.57** for back-to-front, and the total number of blocking events is **~950** versus **6,525** (Figure 3) — random lets many rows stow simultaneously, while back-to-front forces one-by-one stowing.

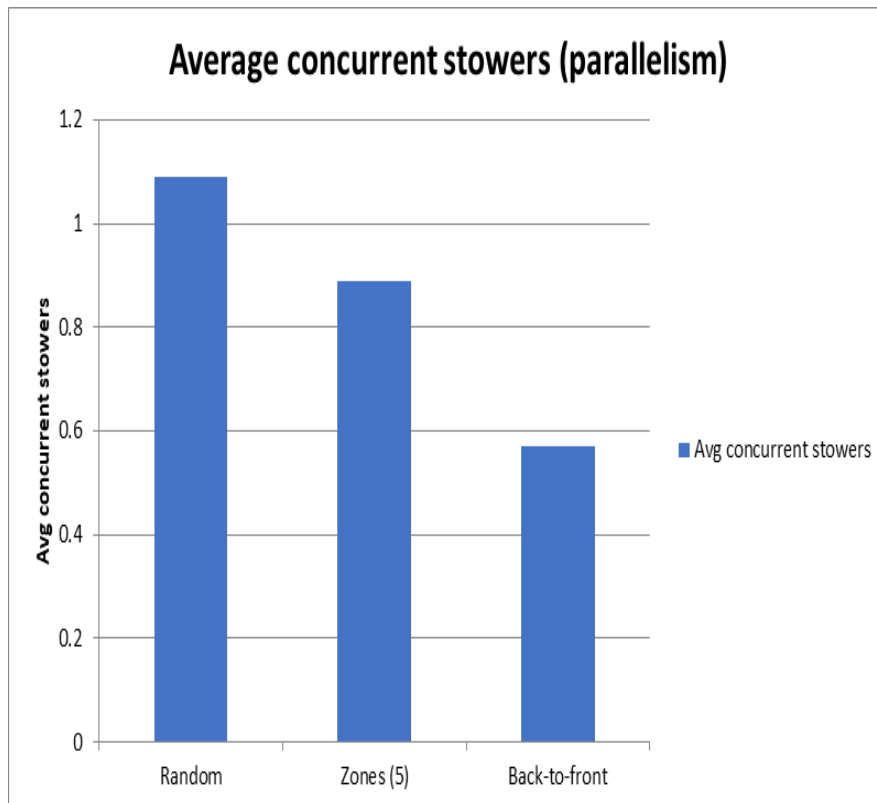


Figure 3. Average parallelism (concurrent stowing) by strategy.

Exact theory. Implementing the recurrence of Section 2.4 gives the same value as the simulation, **bit-for-bit**:

Case	T (simulation)	T (theory)	Match
Random, R=30, S=3 (one run)	325	325	OK
Zones (5), R=30, S=3 (one run)	404	404	OK
Back-to-front, R=30, S=3	627	627	OK
Strided descending, R=30, S=3	286	286	OK
Strided descending, R=30, S=6	394	394	OK

A brute-force sweep over $R = 1..8$, $S = 1..5$, four boarding patterns and up to 6 seats per row (25,600 cases) gave **0 mismatches**. The recurrence is therefore an exact theory of the process, not an approximation.

3.4 A faster strategy: strided descending boarding

We also tested a family of "interleaved" orders in which rows are boarded in strided groups (rows 1, 7, 13, 19, 25, then 2, 8, 14, 20, 26, ...). The key finding is that the **direction within each group matters critically**: boarding each group in **descending** order (... , 19, 13, 7, 1) is far faster than ascending, and it actually **beats random boarding**:

Strategy	S = 1	S = 3	S = 6
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Random	239.1	331.1	472.2
Zones (5)	250.0	400.8	628.7
Back-to-front	325	627	1080
Strided ascending (stride 6)	322	562	922
Strided descending (stride 6)	214	286	394

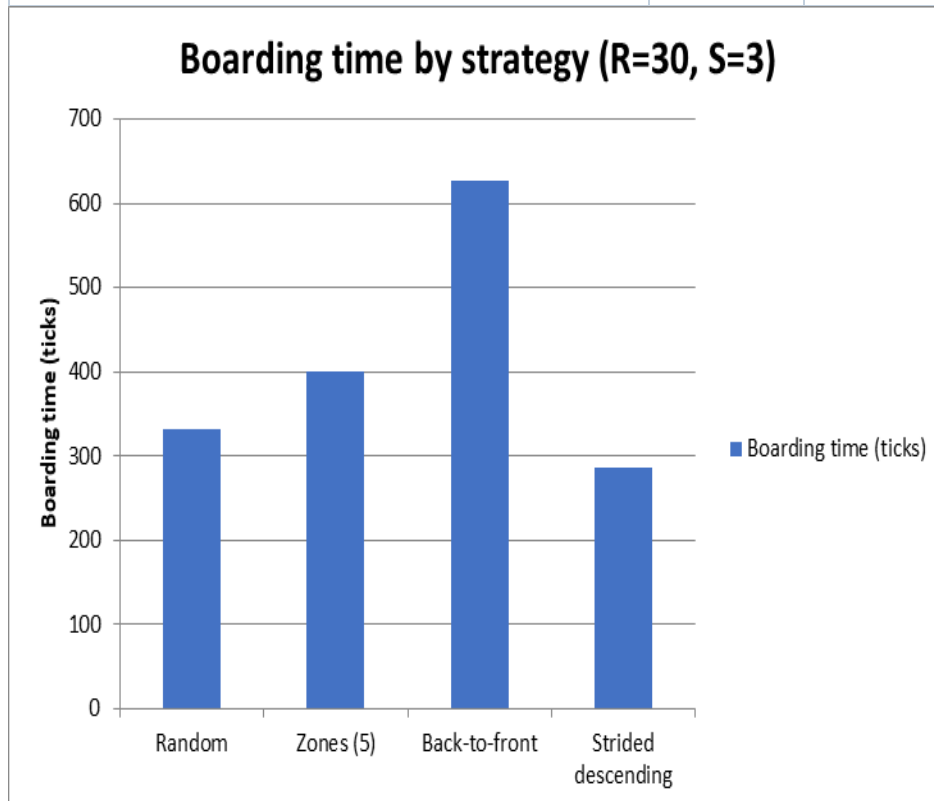


Figure 4. Boarding time by strategy, including the strided-descending order (R=30, S=3).

Strided descending boarding is the fastest — e.g. **286 vs 331** ($\approx 14\%$ faster) at $S = 3$ — and the advantage grows with S ($\approx 17\%$ at $S = 6$). The theory reproduces these values exactly (286/286). At $R = 30$, $S = 3$ the best stride is 6 (stride 5 $\rightarrow$ 342, 6 $\rightarrow$ 286, 8 $\rightarrow$ 328, 10 $\rightarrow$ 370). **Mechanism:** in descending order each next passenger stops at a row *before* the previous stower, so nobody has to squeeze past an occupied cell; ascending order does the opposite and creates cascading blocking.

4. Discussion

Random boarding is fastest because it spreads passengers across rows so several rows stow simultaneously (highest parallelism, least blocking). Back-to-front is slowest because its six same-row passengers board consecutively and must stow at one cell one by one — in the theoretical model, a long chain of $+S$ weights on each cell. The sensitivity analysis (Figure 2) confirms the gap grows with stow time S , exactly as the recurrence's $+S$ blocking term predicts.

5. Is there an optimal boarding order? (open question)

The strided descending result shows that random is **not** necessarily optimal. Two facts frame the search for an optimum:

- **Lower bounds.** $T \geq \max(N, 3(R+1)+6S)$. At $R = 30$, $S = 3$ this floor is 180, while the best strategy found gives 286 — so room remains.
- **Mechanism.** Performance is governed by the longest chain of waits (the critical path). A good order keeps stowing spread over many rows and avoids forcing later passengers to pass an occupied cell.

We therefore **conjecture** that a near-optimal order is "descending in spirit": board so that passengers peel off toward the front without ever passing a stower, while spreading stowing across as many rows as possible. The true optimum likely lies between our strided order and the lower bound. Finding (or proving) the globally optimal order is an **open problem**; since the longest-path model evaluates any order efficiently ($O(N \cdot R)$ with preprocessing), it can be used to search the space of orderings, and an analytical argument may yield the optimum directly. We leave this to future work.

6. Limitations and Future Work

- Simplified model: no assigned-seat interference, no dual aisle or second door.
- The theoretical recurrence uses a naive $O(N)$ search for j ; it can be reduced to $O(N \cdot R)$ overall with preprocessing.
- Future work: add the "Steffen method" and window–middle–aisle boarding; test a model in which parallelism is disabled as a direct causal test.

7. Conclusion

Dispersed (random) boarding outperforms clustered (back-to-front) boarding. We explain this with a mechanism metric (parallelism) corroborated by an **exact longest-path (max-plus) model** that computes the boarding time without simulation and matches it bit-for-bit. Clustering same-row passengers stacks stowing weights on a single aisle cell and lengthens the critical path — the underlying principle behind the observed gap.

References

Steffen, J. H. (2008). Optimal boarding method for airline passengers. *Journal of Air Transport Management*. Van Landeghem, H., & Beuselinck, A. (2002). Reducing passenger boarding time in airplanes. *European Journal of Operational Research*. Bachmat, E., et al. (2006). Analysis of airplane boarding via space-time geometry and random matrix theory.